In Their Own Words

A worksheet for what your loved one wants, before the family decides.

When a decision is close, relatives start speaking for your loved one. “She'd never want that.” “He'll be fine with it.” They may turn out to be right. Until your loved one says so, those are still the family's words.

Fill this in from what your loved one has actually said, this week or years ago. Write it as close to their wording as you can, with a rough date. Where they haven't said anything, write “hasn't said” and leave it. You can ask over several days; it doesn't have to be one sitting.

What they have said they want

About the decision that's coming, or about how they want to live. Only things they said themselves, with a rough date.

FOR EXAMPLE “I want to stay where I can see my garden.” Said in March, and again last week.

A good day, as they describe it

Ask what a good day looks like, from getting up to going to bed. Write the answer the way it comes.

FOR EXAMPLE “Coffee on the porch before anybody talks to me. The crossword. A call from one of the kids.”

What they want to keep

The routines and everyday choices they've told you they want kept, whatever gets decided.

FOR EXAMPLE “I pick what I eat and when I eat it. And I'm not giving up church on Sunday.”

What worries them

Their worries, in their words. The family's worries go on another page.

FOR EXAMPLE “I don't want everybody deciding things about me while I'm in the other room.”

What the family believes they want, but they haven't said

Things relatives say on their behalf. Note who says it. Each one stays here until your loved one has been asked.

FOR EXAMPLE My brother says “she'd never want that.” We haven't asked.

Who wrote this down, and on which days you asked

What this shows you

Three things: what your loved one has said for themselves, what the family has been saying for them, and what nobody has asked yet. It doesn't show what the family should decide. Nothing here adds up to a score, and it isn't a profile of your loved one. Where the family agrees, where it doesn't, and what the choice should rest on are for the family conversation and the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what your loved one has said, apart from what the family assumes. The care interview picks up from there: it goes through their daily life area by area, so their wishes sit next to a complete picture of their situation, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›